

Farm Bills: Major Legislative Actions, 1965-2026

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Farm Bills: Major Legislative Actions, 1965-2026

The farm bill provides an opportunity for Congress to address agricultural and food issues comprehensively about every five years. Over time, farm bills have tended to become more complicated and politically sensitive. As a result, the timeline for reauthorization has become less certain. Recent farm bills have been subject to various developments that have delayed enactment, such as insufficient votes to pass the House floor, presidential vetoes, and extensions.

The most recent farm bill, the Agriculture Improvement Act of 2018 (2018 farm bill; P.L. 115-334), expired in 2023. It has been extended three times, for a year at a time, most recently in November 2025 to cover FY2026 (P.L. 119-37, Division E, §5002). Policies covering crop years 2026-2031 are partially addressed by a budget reconciliation law enacted in 2025.

In 2025, Congress amended selected provisions of the 2018 farm bill through an agriculture title (Title I) in an FY2025 budget reconciliation law (P.L. 119-21). The FY2025 budget reconciliation law included changes to some farm bill programs with mandatory spending. Budget reconciliation rules did not allow policy changes that did not have a mandatory spending budgetary effect. This left some farm bill programs facing expiration and legislators seeking changes in a subsequent farm bill reauthorization package.

In 2026, the House passed the Farm, Food, and National Security Act of 2026 (H.R. 7567) to amend and reauthorize farm bill programs. The bill was introduced on February 13, 2026, passed by the House Committee on Agriculture on March 5, and passed by the chamber on April 30. The Senate Committee on Agriculture, Nutrition, and Forestry reported a farm bill, the Agricultural Act of 2026, on September 16, 2026, after marking up a discussion draft on August 6.

The 2018 farm bill took eight months from introduction to passage, though it did not pass in the initial House vote. The 2014 farm bill took more than 21 months from introduction to enactment, did not pass in the initial House vote, and spanned the 112th and 113th Congresses, including a one-year extension. The 2008 farm bill took more than a year to enact and was complicated by revenue provisions from another committee of jurisdiction, temporary extensions, and vetoes.

This report summarizes the major legislative milestones for the last 12 farm bills.

Contents

Current Farm Bill Reauthorization Timeline..... 1

Historical Farm Bill Reauthorization Timelines..... 3

 Extensions 3

 Presidential Vetoes 4

Potential Implications for Congress 4

Figures

Figure 1. Major Legislative Actions on Farm Bills, 1965-2026..... 2

Tables

Table 1. Major Legislative Actions on Farm Bills, 1965-2026 5

Contacts

Author Information..... 10

A *farm bill* is a collection of laws and changes to laws that authorize, reauthorize, or amend various food, agriculture, and rural policies. Congress has passed farm bills about every five years for nearly a century. A periodic farm bill provides Congress with an opportunity to reexamine agriculture and food policies and programs.¹ Over time, farm bills have tended to become more complicated and politically sensitive. This has made the timeline for reauthorization less certain. Recent farm bills have experienced delayed enactment, extensions, insufficient votes to pass on the floor of a chamber, and presidential vetoes.

This report examines the major legislative milestones for the current reauthorization and past 12 farm bills over 62 years, a period representing the evolution of modern farm bills with growing complexity and a diverse content of policy titles. **Table 1** contains a history of major legislative action on farm bills since 1965.

Figure 1 shows the major dates on a timeline using the two-year congressional sessions for each farm bill.

Current Farm Bill Reauthorization Timeline

The most recent farm bill, the Agriculture Improvement Act of 2018 (2018 farm bill; P.L. 115-334), expired in 2023. It was extended three times, for a year at a time: in November 2023 to cover FY2024 and crop year 2024 (P.L. 118-22, Division B, §102); in December 2024 to cover FY2025 and crop year 2025 (P.L. 118-158, Division D, §4101); and in November 2025 to cover FY2026 (P.L. 119-37, Division E, §5002). Policy for crop years 2026-2031 is partially covered by a 2025 budget reconciliation law, as discussed below.

In 2024, the House Committee on Agriculture ordered reported a farm bill, H.R. 8467, the Farm, Food, and National Security Act of 2024.² The Senate Committee on Agriculture, Nutrition, and Forestry did not mark up a farm bill.

In 2025, Congress amended selected provisions of the 2018 farm bill through an agriculture title (Title I) in an FY2025 budget reconciliation law (P.L. 119-21). The FY2025 budget reconciliation law included changes to some farm bill programs with mandatory spending, including farm bill titles for farm commodities, nutrition, crop insurance, and conservation, as well as relatively smaller programs in the trade, research, energy, horticulture, and miscellaneous titles with mandatory spending. The FY2025 budget reconciliation law did not reauthorize or address all farm bill programs. Budget reconciliation rules did not allow policy changes that did not have a mandatory spending budgetary effect. Budget reconciliation did not address changes to authorizations for discretionary spending programs. This left some farm bill programs facing expiration and legislators seeking changes through a subsequent farm bill reauthorization package.³

In 2026, the House has passed the Farm, Food, and National Security Act of 2026 (H.R. 7567) to amend and reauthorize farm bill programs. The bill was introduced on February 13, 2026, passed by the House Committee on Agriculture on March 5, and passed by the chamber on April 30. The Senate Committee on Agriculture, Nutrition, and Forestry reported a farm bill on September 16,

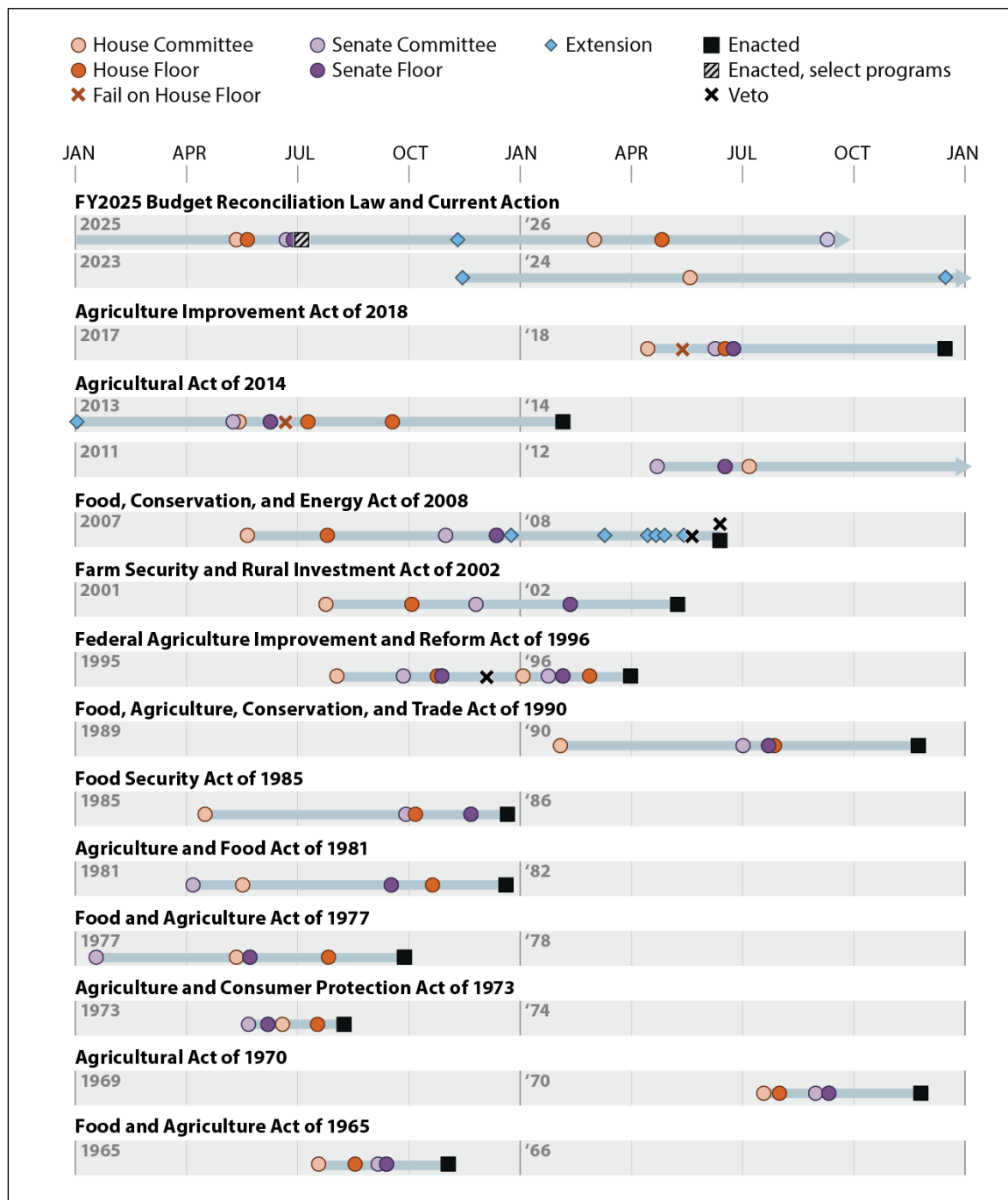
¹ See CRS In Focus IF12047, *Farm Bill Primer: Overview and Status*.

² See CRS Report R48167, *The 2024 Farm Bill: H.R. 8467 Compared with Current Law*.

³ See CRS Report R48775, *The Farm Bill After FY2025 Budget Reconciliation: Frequently Asked Questions*.

2026, the Agricultural Act of 2026.⁴ A discussion draft was released on June 23, a markup was held on August 6, and a final vote to report the bill occurred on September 16.⁵

Figure I. Major Legislative Actions on Farm Bills, 1965-2026



Source: CRS.

⁴ Senate Committee on Agriculture, Nutrition, and Forestry, "Agricultural Act of 2026, as an original bill, with amendments," August 6, 2026, <https://www.agriculture.senate.gov/hearings/business-meeting-08-06-2026>.

⁵ See CRS Report R48918, *The 2026 Farm Bill: Comparison of the House and Senate Bills with Current Law*.

Historical Farm Bill Reauthorization Timelines

In the past seven decades, most farm bills were introduced in the first session of a two-year Congress. Over time, farm bills have generally taken longer to complete, sometimes extending into the second session of Congress but usually completed within a 12-month period.⁶ Two of the three most recent farm bills started in one Congress, were not completed, and were reintroduced in the next Congress. The duration of the conference committee's course after both chambers have passed a bill generally also has become longer.

The current farm bill reauthorization period is the longest on record, spanning the 118th and 119th Congresses. It is the first farm bill partially completed by using budget reconciliation.

The second longest farm bill reauthorization was the 2014 farm bill, which took more than 21 months from its introduction in 2012 to enactment in 2014. It began in the 112th Congress and was reintroduced in the 113th Congress. In 2013, the bill did not pass in the initial House vote; the House then passed separate farm and nutrition assistance bills—the first time a chamber-passed farm bill did not include a nutrition title since 1973. The House later procedurally recombined the bills for conference with the Senate.

The shortest farm bill debate in the past seven decades was the 1973 farm bill, which was enacted less than three months after being introduced.

The 2018 reauthorization period was a relatively short eight months but included some procedural hurdles. The bill did not pass in the initial House vote before it was reconsidered and passed a month later.

Extensions

Extensions of a prior farm bill while its successor is being written had been atypical but are now common in three of the past four reauthorizations (resulting in extensions during 2008, 2013, and 2024-2026).

When the 2002 farm bill expired, portions of it were extended six times for less than a year total beginning in December 2007.⁷ These extensions were for relatively short periods totaling about five months during final House and Senate negotiations.

When the 2008 farm bill expired, the entire farm bill was extended in January 2013 for all of FY2013 and the 2013 crop year.⁸

When extensions were enacted for both the 2002 and 2008 farm bills, each had been expired for about three months (from October through December in 2007 and 2012, respectively) before extensions were enacted beginning in December. While the 2014 farm bill was expired from October 1 until the 2018 farm bill was enacted in February 2018, a continuing resolution for appropriations continued many program operations, though some new program activity had ceased.⁹

In 2023, no markups or floor action had occurred to reauthorize the 2018 farm bill by the time it expired. Congress enacted a one-year extension in November 2023. A second one-year extension

⁶ These dates span only the official introduction of a bill marked up by committee until the President signed the bill. They do not include background hearings before committee markup, which would extend the timeline.

⁷ CRS Report RL34154, *Possible Expiration (or Extension) of the 2002 Farm Bill*.

⁸ CRS Report R42442, *Expiration and Extension of the 2008 Farm Bill*.

⁹ CRS Report R45341, *Expiration of the 2014 Farm Bill*.

of the 2018 farm bill was enacted at the end of the 118th Congress.¹⁰ A third one-year extension was enacted in November 2025 to cover FY2026, after some parts of the farm bill—namely the commodities title—had been reauthorized as part of budget reconciliation.¹¹

Presidential Vetoes

Presidential vetoes of farm bills have not been common. President George W. Bush vetoed the 2008 farm bill (H.R. 2419). When Congress overrode the veto to enact P.L. 110-234, it accidentally enrolled the law without Title III (the trade title). Congress immediately reintroduced the same bill with the trade title (H.R. 6124). President Bush vetoed this version as well, and Congress again overrode the veto to enact P.L. 110-246, a complete 2008 farm bill that included the trade title. The overrides in 2008 were the only time that a farm bill was enacted as a result of a veto override.

President Clinton vetoed a 1995 budget reconciliation package that included the first version of what became the 1996 farm bill, but the veto was not due to the farm bill itself but rather the controversial nature of the reconciliation bill in which the farm bill was embedded.

Prior to 1965, the first veto of a farm bill was in 1956, when President Eisenhower vetoed H.R. 12 (84th Congress), the first version of the Agricultural Act of 1956.

Potential Implications for Congress

Farm bill reauthorization has tended to become more complex and produce greater political sensitivity. The process of enacting a new farm bill prior to the expiration of the then current law has become more difficult. As stakeholders in the farm bill have become more diverse, more people are affected by the legislative uncertainty around the farm bill process. This lack of certainty may compound questions about the availability of future program benefits. Experiences from delays in reauthorization may prompt legislators to propose that some programs be amended to have longer or permanent authorizations so that they do not expire. Prioritization given to some programs may cause them to become separated from the farm bill and amended through other legislative vehicles. Such divisions may be temporary or may gradually reduce the breadth of the farm bill and its coalition. Repeated extensions may not achieve updates to programs to reflect inflation, changing budget considerations, or evolution in societal, business, or academic practices.

¹⁰ CRS Report R47659, *Expiration of the 2018 Farm Bill and Extension for 2025*.

¹¹ CRS Report R48775, *The Farm Bill After FY2025 Budget Reconciliation: Frequently Asked Questions*.

Table I. Major Legislative Actions on Farm Bills, 1965-2026

	House		Senate		Conference Report Approval			Public Law
	Cmte.	Passage	Cmte.	Passage	Conf. Report	House Passage	Senate Passage	
Farm, Food, and National Security Act of 2026 Would cover until 9/30/2031	3/5/2026 H.R. 7567 Vote of 34-17 4/21/2026 H.Rept. 119-620	4/30/2026 H.R. 7567 Vote of 224-200	9/16/2026 Reported text with amendments Vote of 12-11	—	—	—	—	—
Further one-year extension Covers until 9/30/2026 unless a later date was specified in other law	One-year extension until 9/30/2026 of provisions in the 2018 farm bill that were not already extended or reauthorized to a later date in other legislation, such as P.L. 119-21.							11/12/2025 P.L. 119-37, Division E, §5002
An Act to Provide for Reconciliation Pursuant to Title II of H. Con. Res. 14 (FY2025 Budget Reconciliation Law) Covers 2025-2031 crop years and funding for certain programs until 9/30/2031	5/14/2025 Committee text Vote of 29-25	5/22/2025 H.R. 1, Title I H.Rept. 119-106 Vote of 215-214	6/25/2025 Committee text	7/1/2025 S.Amdt. 2360, Title I, to H.R. 1 Vote of 51-50	—	7/3/2025 H.R. 1 Vote of 218-214	7/1/2025 H.R. 1 Vote of 51-50	7/4/2025 P.L. 119-21, Title I
Further one-year extension Covers 2025 crop year or until 9/30/2025	One-year extension until 9/30/2025 and for the 2025 crop year.							12/21/2024 P.L. 118-158, Division D, §4101
Farm, Food, and National Security Act of 2024 Would have covered 2025-2029 crop years or until 9/30/2029	5/23/2024 H.R. 8467 Vote of 33-21	—	11/18/2024 S. 5335 introduced	—	—	—	—	—
One-year extension of the 2018 farm bill Covers 2024 crop year or until 9/30/2024	One-year extension until 9/30/2024 and for the 2024 crop year.							11/16/2023 P.L. 118-22, Division B, §102
2018 farm bill Agriculture Improvement Act of 2018 Covers 2019-2023 crop years or until 9/30/2023	4/18/2018 H.R. 2 Vote of 26-20 5/3/2018 H.Rept. 115-661	5/18/2018 H.R. 2 Initial vote failed by 198-213 6/21/2018 Reconsidered under H.Res. 905 Passed by vote of 213-211	6/13/2018 S. 3042 Vote of 20-1	6/28/2018 H.R. 2 Vote of 86-11	12/10/2018 H.Rept. 115-1072	12/12/2018 H.R. 2 Vote of 369-47	12/11/2018 H.R. 2 Vote of 87-13	12/20/2018 P.L. 115-334

	House		Senate		Conference Report Approval			Public Law
	Cmte.	Passage	Cmte.	Passage	Conf. Report	House Passage	Senate Passage	
2014 farm bill	5/15/2013	6/20/2013	5/14/2013	6/10/2013	1/27/2014	1/29/2014	2/4/2014	2/7/2014
Agricultural Act of 2014	H.R. 1947	H.R. 1947	S. 954	S. 954	H.Rept. 113-333	H.R. 2642	H.R. 2642	P.L. 113-79
(113 th Congress)	Vote of 36-10	Failed by vote 195-234	Vote of 15-5	Vote of 66-27		Vote of 251-166	Vote of 68-32	
Covers 2014-2018 crop years or until 9/30/2018	5/29/2013 H.Rept. 113-92	7/11/2013 H.R. 2642 Farm portion vote of 216-208 9/19/2013 H.R. 3102 Nutrition part vote of 217-210 9/28/2013 H.Res. 361 combined House bills	9/4/2013 S.Rept. 113-88					
One-year extension of the 2008 farm bill	One-year extension until 9/30/2013 and for the 2013 crop year.							1/2/2013 P.L. 112-240 Title VII
Covers 2013 crop year or until 9/30/2013								
Agriculture Reform, Food, and Jobs Act	7/11/2012	—	4/26/2012	6/21/2012	—	—	—	—
(112 th Congress)	H.R. 6083		S. 3240	S. 3240				
	Vote of 35-11		Vote of 16-5	Vote of 64-35				
	9/13/2012 H.Rept. 112-669		8/28/2012 S.Rept. 112-203					
Early partial extension of the 2008 farm bill	Extended five conservation programs through FY2014.							11/18/2011 P.L. 112-55

	House		Senate		Conference Report Approval			Public Law
	Cmte.	Passage	Cmte.	Passage	Conf. Report	House Passage	Senate Passage	
2008 farm bill Food, Conservation, and Energy Act of 2008 Covers 2008-2012 crop years or until 9/30/2012						6/18/2008 H.R. 6124 Passed over veto 317-109	6/18/2008 H.R. 6124 Passed over veto 80-14	6/18/2008 P.L. 110-246
					Repassed as new bill with Title III	5/22/2008 H.R. 6124 Vote of 306-110	6/5/2008 H.R. 6124 Vote of 77-15	6/18/2008 Vetoed
						5/21/2008 H.R. 2419 Passed over veto 316-108	5/22/2008 H.R. 2419 Passed over veto 82-13	5/22/2008 P.L. 110-234
	5/22/2007 H.R. 2419	7/27/2007 H.R. 2419	11/2/2007 S. 2302	12/14/2007 S.Amdt. 3500 to H.R. 2419	5/13/2008 H.Rept. 110-627	5/14/2008 H.R. 2419 Vote of 318-106	5/15/2008 H.R. 2419 Vote of 81-15	5/21/2008 Vetoed Enrolling error omitted Title III
Short-term extension of the 2002 farm bill	Continued extension until 5/23/2008.							5/18/2008 P.L. 110-231
Short-term extension	Continued extension until 5/16/2008.							5/2/2008 P.L. 110-208
Short-term extension	Continued extension until 5/2/2008.							4/25/2008 P.L. 110-205
Short-term extension	Continued extension until 4/25/2008.							4/18/2008 P.L. 110-200
Short-term extension	Continued extension until 4/18/2008 and added extension of suspension of permanent law.							3/14/2008 P.L. 110-196
Short-term extension	Extended parts of the 2002 farm bill until 3/15/2008; did not extend the direct and countercyclical farm commodity programs.							12/26/2007 P.L. 110-161 Division A, §751
Early partial extension of the 2002 farm bill during budget reconciliation	Extended an early-expiring dairy program for two years from 9/2005 through 8/2007 and two conservation programs until FY2010.							2/8/2006 P.L. 109-171

	House		Senate		Conference Report Approval			
	Cmte.	Passage	Cmte.	Passage	Conf. Report	House Passage	Senate Passage	Public Law
2002 farm bill Farm Security and Rural Investment Act of 2002 Covers 2002-2007 crop years or until 9/30/2007	7/26/2001 H.R. 2646 8/2/2001 H.Rept. 107-191	10/5/2001 H.R. 2646 Vote of 291-120	11/27/2001 S. 1731 12/7/2001 S.Rept. 107-117	2/13/2002 Amdt. to H.R. 2646 Vote of 58-40	5/1/2002 H.Rept. 107-424	5/2/2002 H.R. 2646 Vote of 280-141	5/8/2002 H.R. 2646 Vote of 64-35	5/13/2002 P.L. 107-171
1996 farm bill Federal Agriculture Improvement and Reform Act of 1996 Covers 1996-2002 crop years or until 9/30/2002	1/5/1996 H.R. 2854 Vote of 29-17 2/9/1996 H.Rept. 104-462	2/29/1996 H.R. 2854 Vote of 270-155	1/26/1996 S. 1541 3/12/1996 Amdt. to H.R. 2854 Voice vote	2/7/1996 S. 1541 Vote of 64-32	3/25/1996 H.Rept. 104-494	3/29/1996 H.R. 2854 Vote of 318-89	3/28/1996 H.R. 2854 Vote of 74-26	4/4/1996 P.L. 104-127
Balanced Budget Act of 1995, Title I (Agricultural Reconciliation Act of 1995)	10/26/1995 H.R. 2491, Title I includes H.R. 2195	H.R. 2491 10/26/1995 Vote of 227-203	10/28/1995 S. 1357, Title I	10/28/1995 Amdt. to H.R. 2491 Vote of 52-47	11/16/1995 H.Rept. 104-347	11/20/1995 H.R. 2491 Vote of 235-192	11/17/1995 H.R. 2491 Vote of 52-47	12/6/1995 Vetoed
Freedom to Farm Act	8/4/1995 H.R. 2195 9/20/1995 fails cmte.	—	9/28/1995 unnumbered bill	—	—	—	—	—
Early partial extension of the 1990 farm bill	Extended the dairy program until 1996 and extended programs for wheat, feed grains, cotton, rice, peanuts, wool, and mohair until 1997 and honey until 1998.							8/10/1993 P.L. 103-66
1990 farm bill Food, Agriculture, Conservation, and Trade Act of 1990 Covers 1991-1995 crop years or until 9/30/1995	2/5/1990 H.R. 3950 7/3/1990 H.Rept. 101-569	8/1/1990 H.R. 3950 Vote of 327-91	7/6/1990 S. 2830 S.Rept. 101-357	7/27/1990 S. 2830 Vote of 70-21	10/22/1990 H.Rept. 101-916	10/23/1990 S. 2830 Vote of 318-102	10/25/1990 S. 2830 Vote of 60-36	11/28/1990 P.L. 101-624
1985 farm bill Food Security Act of 1985 Covers 1986-1990 crop years or until 9/30/1990	4/17/1985 H.R. 2100 9/13/1985 H.Rept. 99-271	10/8/1985 H.R. 2100 Vote of 282-141	9/30/1985 S. 1714 S.Rept. 99-145	11/23/1985 H.R. 2100 Vote of 61-28	12/17/1985 H.Rept. 99-447	12/18/1985 H.R. 2100 Vote of 325-96	12/18/1985 H.R. 2100 Vote of 55-38	12/23/1985 P.L. 99-198

	House		Senate		Conference Report Approval			Public Law
	Cmte.	Passage	Cmte.	Passage	Conf. Report	House Passage	Senate Passage	
1981 farm bill Agriculture and Food Act of 1981 Covers 1982-1985 crop years or until 9/30/1985	5/18/1981 H.R. 3603 5/19/1981 H.Rept. 97-106	10/22/1981 S. 884 Vote of 192-160	4/7/1981 S. 884 5/27/1981 S.Rept. 97-126	9/18/1981 S. 884 Vote of 49-32	12/9/1981 H.Rept. 97-377 12/10/1981 S.Rept. 97-290	12/16/1981 S. 884 Vote of 205-203	12/10/1981 S. 884 Vote of 67-32	12/22/1981 P.L. 97-98
1977 farm bill Food and Agriculture Act of 1977 Covers 1978-1981 crop years or until 9/30/1981	5/13/1977 H.R. 7171 5/16/1977 H.Rept. 95-348	7/28/1977 Amdt. to S. 275 Vote of 294-114	1/18/1977 S. 275 5/16/1977 S.Rept. 95-180	5/24/1977 S. 275 Vote of 69-18	9/9/1977 S.Rept. 95-418	9/16/1977 S. 275 Vote of 283-107	9/9/1977 S. 275 Vote of 63-8	9/29/1977 P.L. 95-113
1973 farm bill Agriculture and Consumer Protection Act of 1973 Covers 1974-1977 crop years or until 6/30/1977	6/20/1973 H.R. 8860 6/27/1973 H.Rept. 93-337	7/19/1973 Amdt. to S. 1888 Vote of 226-182	5/23/1973 S. 1888 S.Rept. 93-173	6/8/1973 S. 1888 Vote of 78-9	7/31/1973 H.Rept. 93-427	8/3/1973 S. 1888 Vote of 252-151	7/31/1973 S. 1888 Vote of 85-7	8/10/1973 P.L. 93-86
1970 farm bill Agricultural Act of 1970 Covers 1971-1973 crop years	7/23/1970 H.R. 18546 H.Rept. 91-1329	8/5/1970 H.R. 18546 Vote of 212-171	9/4/1970 Amdt. to H.R. 18546 S.Rept. 91-1154	9/15/1970 Amdt. to H.R. 18546 Vote of 65-7	10/9/1970 H.Rept. 91-1594	10/13/1970 H.R. 18546 Vote of 191-145	11/19/1970 H.R. 18546 Vote of 48-35	11/30/1970 P.L. 91-524
Early extension of the 1965 farm bill	More than a year before expiration, extended the farm bill for one-year until 12/31/1970.							10/11/1968 P.L. 90-559
1965 farm bill Food and Agriculture Act of 1965 Covers 1966-1969 crop years	7/20/1965 H.R. 9811 H.Rept. 89-631	8/19/1965 H.R. 9811 Vote of 221-172	9/7/1965 Amdt. to H.R. 9811 S.Rept. 89-687	9/14/1965 Amdt. to H.R. 9811 Vote of 72-22	10/6/1965 H.Rept. 89-1123	10/8/1965 H.R. 9811 Vote of 219-150	10/12/1965 H.R. 9811 Voice vote	11/4/1965 P.L. 89-321

Source: CRS using Congress.gov, <http://www.congress.gov>.

Notes: Includes only major legislative actions. Excludes subsequent revisions outside a farm bill, except as noted. Rows are sorted by date of the Public Law column.

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